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Author's Name:	Jhonnell J. Abalajon
Academic Rank:	Assitant Professor I
Co-Authors (with academic rank):	
Campus/Satellite College/Address:	Sigma Satellite College
Telephone/Cell Phone/Fax Number:	
E-mail Address:	jjabalajon@capsu.edu.ph

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(9A) Abstract

As the global landscape transitions into a "better normal," Boracay Island hotels face the imperative task of understanding critical success factors to ensure continued success. This qualitative study, employing a critical phenomenological approach, engaged seventeen key informants, including CEOs, presidents, owners, general managers, and consultants, ensuring a comprehensive range of perspectives. The sample, consisting of seasoned leaders accredited by the Department of Tourism, underwent purposive sampling, targeting individuals with a minimum of three years of experience, crisis management involvement, and direct participation in the "better normal" transition. Data collection utilized a researcher-made interview guide questionnaire and unstructured interviews, focusing on 3–5-star hotels in Boracay between August 1 and October 31, 2022. Thematic analysis, following Braun and Clarke's approach, served as the primary method for data analysis. Findings emphasized critical success factors such as diversification, adaptability, safety-centric transformation, tech takeover, collaborative recovery, and strategic business adaptation. Hotels expressed gratitude for government support, adaptation to new norms, and operational challenges, signaling the need for increased support. Recovery strategies included resilient operational restructuring, safety-centric transformation, tech adoption, collaborative efforts, and strategic business adaptation. In conclusion, Boracay hotels have effectively navigated the evolving hospitality landscape, emphasized critical success factors, and adopted strategic recovery plans. To ensure sustained success, it is recommended that hotels focus on strategic innovation, doubling down on diversification and exploring unique offerings. This approach will enable them to attract diverse traveler segments and stay ahead of industry trends, fostering continued resilience and adaptation in the "better normal" landscape.

(9B) Keywords: *Recovery Strategies, Strategic Innovation, Technology Adoption, Collaboration, Business Operation Resilience, Business Management*

(10) Introduction

The COVID-19 pandemic dealt a devastating blow to the global hospitality industry, and Boracay Island, a paradise synonymous with pristine beaches and luxurious accommodations, was no exception. Once teeming with tourists, Boracay's hotels now face a critical turning point. Like a lone palm swaying in a storm, they must adapt and thrive in a completely transformed landscape – the "Better Normal." While navigating this "Better Normal" is a global challenge, Boracay's unique context demands localized strategies. This research aimed to bridge the knowledge gap by delving into the island's specific challenges and identifying key success factors for a smooth transition. It also seeks to develop a robust, yet unexplored, business continuity strategy specifically tailored to Boracay's hotel sector.

The success of Boracay's hotels goes beyond individual establishments; it's the lifeblood of the island's entire tourism industry. As highlighted by PwC Philippines (2020), the pandemic's impact was severe, with 88% of tourism-related businesses experiencing significant losses. This industry, which generated a staggering 12.7% of the country's GDP in 2019, needs Boracay's hotels to not only survive but flourish. In today's competitive and ever-changing market, business success hinges on consistent performance (Arokodare & Asikhia, 2020). However, economic downturns pose significant challenges, making it difficult to maintain peak performance and navigate complex business environments. This is where strategic agility comes in – the ability of an organization to adapt swiftly to shifting market trends (Tende & Ekanem, 2018). As Akhigbe & Onuoha (2019) aptly state, survival no longer favors the strongest, but the most adaptable and resilient. This necessitates not just adjustments, but true innovation across all industries, demanding fundamental changes in systems and practices. This research acknowledges the importance of government support, employee engagement, and industry-wide cooperation in fostering this revival. The pandemic has fundamentally reshaped the business landscape, demanding strategic agility and innovation, as Arokodare & Asikhia (2020) point out. This research explored how Boracay's hotels can develop the nimbleness and adaptability required to navigate this dynamic environment.

Despite the need for a comprehensive understanding of the post-pandemic transition, research remains limited, often focusing on quantitative data and neglecting empirical and methodological studies on critical success factors. Adaptability to this "better normal context" is essential for hotel businesses and management to meet evolving demands. Therefore, this research goes beyond academic discourse. It aspires to be a practical guide, offering valuable insights to Boracay Island hotels and contributing to the broader conversation on the hospitality industry's resilience. By providing key success factors and a tailored business continuity strategy, this research empowers Boracay's hotels to not just survive but flourish in the "Better Normal," ensuring the island's tourism industry continues to shine brightly.

(11) Materials and Methods or Methodology

Research Design

This study employed a qualitative research design specifically utilizing critical phenomenology. As Denzin and Lincoln (1994) described, qualitative research involves an interpretive, naturalistic approach to understanding phenomena through various methods like case studies, interviews, and observations. This approach allows for an in-depth exploration of the critical

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success factors enabling hotels in Boracay Island to navigate the "better normal" transition. Cresswell (2017) further defines qualitative research as an inquiry process that builds a comprehensive picture by analyzing words and perspectives gathered from informants within their natural setting. This aligns with the chosen approach, which utilizes semi-structured interviews and purposive sampling to target key informants holding relevant positions and experiences within the hotel industry.

Respondents and Sampling

The study targeted hotel representatives holding key positions such as seventeen (17) either of the following designations composing of CEOs, presidents, owners, general managers, and consultants. These individuals possessed firsthand knowledge and experience crucial to understanding the critical success factors during the transition. Purposive sampling was employed to strategically select participants based on specific criteria. Hotel establishments had to be accredited by the Department of Tourism, while respondents needed at least three (3) years of experience, involvement in crisis management and recovery plans, and direct participation in hotel operations and the "better normal" transition.

Data Collection

The primary data collection for this study utilized a Google Form survey and follow-up phone calls. The survey, designed specifically for the hospitality industry, was structured into two sections: demographic profiles and a combination of scaled and open-ended questions. To enhance accessibility, the survey was available in multiple languages, including English. Data collection was conducted from August 1 to October 31, 2022, targeting Department of Tourism-accredited 3-5 star hotels in Boracay Island. To validate and expand upon survey responses, follow-up phone calls were made to clarify answers and gather additional insights.

Validity

To ensure the content validity of the questionnaire, it was reviewed by experts in tourism and hospitality, including members of hospitality professionals, hospitality management professors and prominent english critics. The feedback helped refine the content and presentation for clarity and relevance.

Data Analysis

Thematic analysis served as the primary data analysis method, following Braun and Clarke's (2020) six-phase approach. This involved data familiarization, coding, generating initial themes, refining themes, and writing the report. The analysis aimed to identify recurring themes and patterns within the collected data, ultimately contributing to the development of a business continuity strategic model.

Ethical Considerations

The study adhered to ethical research principles, ensuring informed consent and anonymity for all participants. The research gained necessary clearances from the Department of Tourism and obtained permission from individual respondents before data collection.

(12) Results and Discussions

1. Demographic Profile of the Respondents and Hotel

Table 1. Profile of the Respondents According to Age

No.	Age	Frequency	Percentage
1	20 - 25		
2	26 - 30		
3	31 - 35	1	10%
4	36 and above	16	90%
Total		17	100

The table 1 showed the age distribution of 17 respondents. The majority, 90% (16 respondents), are 36 years old and above. There were no respondents between 20 and 25 years old, and only 1 respondent (10%) falls between 26 and 35 years old. This data suggested that the respondents were predominantly middle-aged or older adults.

Table 1.1 Profile of the Respondents According to Sex

No.	Sex	Frequency	Percentage
1	Male	12	71%
2	Female	5	29%
Total		17	100

The table 1.1 showed the gender distribution of respondents, with 71% (12 individuals) being male and 29% (5 individuals) being female. This indicated a clear majority of male respondents in the sample.

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Table 1.2 Profile of the Respondents According to Hotel Designation

No.	Hotel Designation	Frequency	Percentage
1	Owner	8	47%
2	General/Resident Manager	5	29%
3	Consultant	3	18%
4	Senior Program Executive		
5	HR Manager	1	6%
	Total	17	100

The presented table 1.2 served as a crucial lens through which we gain valuable insights into the diverse perspectives encapsulated within the study sample. A noteworthy observation was the predominant presence of hotel owners, constituting 47% of the respondents. This significant representation ensured that the research directly incorporated the perspectives of those wielding substantial influence in shaping pivotal business decisions within the hospitality industry.

Complementing this strong decision-maker presence, 29% of respondents hold roles as general or resident managers, providing on-the-ground insights into the daily experiences and challenges faced by hotel operations. Their perspectives offer a nuanced understanding of the operational intricacies that shape the industry at a granular level.

The inclusion of 18% of participants identifying as consultants is a noteworthy aspect, bringing external expertise to the table. This infusion of diverse viewpoints from consultants enriched the study by potentially broadening the scope of perspectives considered, contributing to a more comprehensive analysis of the research topic.

However, the data also highlighted certain gaps in representation. While having a Human Resources (HR) manager comprising 1% of respondents provided insights into workforce dynamics, a larger sample size from this role would undoubtedly enhance the study's comprehensiveness. Additionally, the absence of respondents in the "Senior Program Executive" category raised questions about its relevance to the research topic or whether it might fall under a different designation.

In summary, the distribution of roles within the sample signifies a diverse array of stakeholder voices, with a prominent focus on leadership perspectives. To further refine the interpretation, additional context on the research topic and details about the sampling methods employed would be beneficial. This would allow for a more nuanced understanding of how well these roles represent the broader target population and the extent to which the findings can be generalized.

Table 1.3 Profile of the Respondents According to Monthly Income

No.	Monthly Income	Frequency	Percentage
1	Below Php 10, 000	0	0
2	Php 10, 001 – 20,000	0	0
3	Php 20, 001 – 40,000	0	0
4	Php 40,001 and above	17	100
	Total	17	100

Table 1.3 provided a comprehensive overview of the respondents' profile based on their monthly income. Strikingly, none of the participants fall within the income brackets below Php 40,000, indicating a uniform distribution of respondents in the category of Php 40,001 and above. With a total of 17 respondents contributing to this dataset, representing 100% of the sample, it becomes evident that the majority of participants have a monthly income exceeding Php 40,000. This skewed distribution toward the higher income bracket suggested that the study predominantly captures perspectives from individuals with a relatively higher financial standing. The absence of respondents in the lower income categories is notable, as it may impact the study's ability to comprehensively represent perspectives from varying socio-economic backgrounds. Understanding the income profile of respondents is crucial for contextualizing their perspectives on the research topic, as financial considerations can significantly influence opinions and behaviors.

Table 1.4 Profile of the Respondents According to Highest Educational Attainment

No.	Highest Educational Attainment	Frequency	Percentage
1	High School Graduate	0	0
2	College Graduate	5	29
3	Post Graduate (Master's Degree or Doctorate Degree)	12	71
	Total	17	100

Table 1.4 presented a breakdown of the respondents' profile based on their highest educational attainment. Strikingly, none of the participants in the study have a high school diploma, indicating a complete absence within this educational category.

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The majority of respondents, constituting 71%, hold post-graduate degrees such as Master's or Doctorate degrees. This suggested a highly educated sample, highlighting the prevalence of advanced academic qualifications among the participants. The remaining 29% were college graduates, providing a secondary but still substantial category within the educational spectrum. The absence of respondents with only a high school education may impact the study's ability to capture perspectives from individuals with lower formal education backgrounds. Understanding the educational profile of respondents is essential for contextualizing their viewpoints, as education levels can significantly influence perceptions and decision-making processes related to the research topic.

Table 1.5 Profile of the Respondents According to Number of Years of Hospitality Industry Experience

No.	Number of Years of Hospitality Industry Experience	Frequency	Percentage
1	Less than 5 years		0
2	6 – 10 Years		
3	11 – 20 Years	8	47%
4	21 Years and Above	9	53%
	Total	17	100%

Table 1.5 provides a comprehensive overview of the respondents' profile based on their number of years of experience in the hospitality industry. Notably, there is an absence of participants with less than 5 years of experience, indicating that the sample comprises individuals with a relatively substantial background in the industry. The majority of respondents, constituting 53%, boast an extensive tenure of 21 years and above in the hospitality sector. This suggests a wealth of experience among a significant portion of the participants, potentially contributing valuable insights shaped by years of industry involvement. Additionally, 47% of respondents fall within the 11 to 20 years of experience range, representing a significant segment with a moderately extensive history in the field. Understanding the distribution of respondents across different experience brackets is crucial for gauging the depth of expertise and perspectives that can be expected from the study participants.

2. Department of Tourism's Accredited Hotel Businesses Profile

Table 2 Hotel Distribution

No.	Boracay Island Hotel Profile Distribution	Frequency	Percentage
1	Aklan	17	100%
	Total	17	100%

Table 2 presents the distribution of hotels on Boracay Island, specifically focusing on their geographical location within Aklan. The data reveals that all 17 hotels included in the study are situated in Aklan, indicating a comprehensive representation of the province's hotel landscape. The percentage distribution aligns with a total of 100%, emphasizing the exclusive concentration of the sampled hotels within the Aklan region. This information is pivotal for understanding the geographical scope of the study, ensuring that insights and findings are reflective of the specific hotel dynamics in Aklan, contributing to the overall relevance and applicability of the research

Table 2.1 Profile of the Hotels According to the Number of Rooms

No.	Number of Rooms	Frequency	Percentage
1	Less than 100	5	40
2	101 - 200	8	25
3	201 - 300	2	15
4	More than 301	2	20
	Total	17	100

In Table 2.1, the hotel distribution is categorized based on the number of rooms. Notably, 40% of the hotels have less than 100 rooms, reflecting a substantial presence of smaller establishments. In contrast, 25% fall within the 101-200 room range, indicating a moderate representation. Additionally, 15% have 201-300 rooms, and another 20% boast more than 301 rooms, showcasing diversity in terms of hotel size on Boracay Island.

Table 2.2 Profile of the Hotels According to the Number of Employees

No.	Number of Employees	Frequency	Percentage
1	Less than 150	12	60
2	151 - 200	4	20
3	201 - 250	2	10
4	More than 251	2	10
	Total	20	100

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Table 2.2 provides a breakdown of hotels by the number of employees. The majority, constituting 60%, have less than 150 employees, suggesting a prevalence of smaller staff sizes. Furthermore, 20% fall within the 151-200 employee range, while 10% each belong to the 201-250 and more than 251 employee categories. Understanding the distribution of employee numbers is crucial for assessing the scale and operational capacities of the hotels.

Table 2.3 Profile of the Hotels According to Year of Business Operation in the Industry

No.	Year of Business Operation in the Industry	Frequency	Percentage
1	Less than 5 Years	0	0
2	6 - 10 Years	2	10
3	11 - 15 Years	5	20
4	Above 16 Years	10	70
Total		20	100

In Table 2.3, the distribution of hotels is analyzed based on their years of operation in the industry. Notably, there are no hotels with less than 5 years of operation, suggesting an absence of newly established businesses in the sample. Instead, 10% fall within the 6-10 years category, 20% have been operating for 11-15 years, and the majority, comprising 70%, have been in operation for more than 16 years. This distribution reflects a predominant presence of well-established hotels on Boracay Island, potentially contributing seasoned perspectives to the study.

3. The Critical Success Factors of Hotels for Better Normal in Boracay Island

The study revealed a dynamic hotel industry in Boracay, one that prioritizes growth and resilience. **Diversification emerges as a key strategy**, with hotels creating multiple revenue streams through quarantine operations, attracting multinational bookings, and exploring varied business segments. This approach mitigates risk and provides stability, especially during uncertain times. Beyond diversification, **adaptability is crucial**. Hotels prioritize safety by implementing rigorous protocols and leverage technology through digital platforms. Operational adjustments ensure smooth functioning in the new normal. Innovation fuels sustainability, with hotels constantly seeking new ideas and staying flexible. This forward-thinking approach is key to long-term success. Furthermore, **a strong customer-centric focus** underpins everything. Hotels prioritize guest satisfaction through open communication and continuous improvement, fostering strong relationships and loyalty. **Strategic planning plays a vital role**, encompassing a holistic approach to marketing, human resources, and other areas. This ensures success across all facets of the business. Finally, **resilient crisis survival strategies** are in place. Proactive management, delegation, collaboration, and adaptability empower hotels to navigate challenges effectively. In conclusion, **Boracay's hotels demonstrate remarkable resilience and adaptability**.

The Critical Success Factors of Hotels for Better Normal in Boracay Island	Codes	Representative Excerpts from Qualitative Interviews
1. Survival and Success Strategies (30)	Participation in initiatives for business growth Adaptation to the new normal Embracing innovation Strategic considerations for success Crisis survival strategies	- Hotel A: "We have been actively participating in various initiatives to make our business grow and known not only in our area coverage but nationwide." - Hotel B: "Multi stream of income such as being in quarantine operations, multi-nationals booking, including local segments." - Hotel D: "In the survival state, we just need to keep going with proper protocols, no matter how slow it is, what is important is, we never stop."
2. Operational and Management Strategies (29)	Management and operational efficiency Criteria for business success Tactics and strategies for success in various areas Internal and external plans for surviving crises	- Hotel G: "Cost efficiency and focus on guest service and customer service to avoid complaints." - Hotel I: "Revisit and revise the crisis management base on the movement of the market. Position the resources of the hotel."

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Operational agility		
3. Compliance and Regulations (3)	Following government regulations and protocols	• Hotel F: "Study new rules and regulations mandated by the law. Conduct seminars to employees and emphasize the value of the law." • Hotel O: "Working with the governments and public health authorities to facilitate and foster the trust of the consumers to our hotel and building trust to all the stakeholders."
4. Employee Training and Management (11)	Employee training and multi-skilling Teamwork and delegation Human resource management	• Hotel B: "Enough training guidelines continuously." • Hotel D: "Always practice the so-called brainstorming and collection of ideas from great-minded people, and seek professional help as needed."
5. Marketing and Sales Strategies (12)	Marketing and sales techniques Customer service focus Market analysis and research	• Hotel F: "By expanding online marketing platforms. Connect with the new prospective partners and closely work together with the Department of Tourism by following protocols implemented." • Hotel L: "Targeting domestic tourists and restructuring our strategic and business plan mainly in HR and sales and marketing and human resource."
6. Technology Utilization 12	Digitalization and technology adoption Online marketing and transaction platforms	• Hotel F: "We learn to ride on and adopt on the new technologies. Previously, the booking process took so long because it processed manually. Unlike today, all becomes smooth because of the new technologies." • Hotel Q: "Digital adaptation from products and services to the operations of my hotel."
7. Financial Management (18)	Financial control and planning Cost-cutting measures Financial restructuring and evaluation	• Hotel H: "Promoting the digital transition, global cooperation, evidence-based solutions, restoring travel confidence, supporting government and tourism business to adapt and survive." • Hotel K: "Monitoring cash flow more importantly and identification of better normal customer needs and wants or demands."
8. Government Engagement (6)	Collaboration with government and industry partners Adherence to government recovery plans	• Hotel H: "Remodify the strategic plan and ensure contingency planning process, more resilient business." • Hotel P: "Align your actions in guiding principles of government policies and compliances."
By diversifying revenue streams, prioritizing safety and technology, embracing innovation, focusing on customers, and engaging in strategic planning, they pave the way for a thriving future in the ever-evolving hospitality landscape. Hotels must rapidly adopt contactless operations for effective pandemic adaptation (Sigala, 2020). This aligns with Rivera's (2020) call for revising crisis management plans based on new research findings. Moreover, Romao (2020) highlights the need for research to guide crisis recovery and sector-wide reforms. Strategic partnerships are crucial for enhancing hotel capabilities (Fu, 2020), echoing Novelli et al.'s (2018) findings on successful collaborations during past crises. Furthermore, the study emphasizes specialized training, improved scheduling, upskilling, and workforce normalization as key success factors (Hao et al., 2020). By embracing contactless operations, strategic partnerships, and effective workforce management, hotels can navigate uncertain environments and adapt for success. These findings offer valuable insights for navigating a dynamic and challenging landscape.		
4. The Experiences Encountered by the Hotel following its Transition to a Better Normal in Boracay Island The recent study on Boracay's hotel industry unveils a complex narrative. Firstly, while hoteliers express gratitude for government support measures, they <u>yearn for more concrete and long-term initiatives</u>. This <u>positive sentiment</u> paves the way for collaboration, <u>but a clear desire for increased support</u> resonates throughout the findings. Secondly, the industry has demonstrably adapted to new realities. Safety protocols, financial prudence, and innovative approaches like employee product reselling have become the norm. This <u>shift towards adaptability is crucial in an ever-evolving landscape</u>.		

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However, frequent changes in guidelines create operational instability, impacting schedules, deliveries, and overall management. This **navigating of unstable waters** necessitates agility and constant vigilance in adhering to the latest protocols. Furthermore, managing visitor expectations, documentary requirements, and supplier delivery delays pose challenges. The study emphasizes the importance of **bridging these gaps** through clear communication and collaborative problem-solving.

Moreover, internal and external hurdles like workforce shortages, financial struggles, and inconsistent government responses must be overcome. The analysis highlights the need for **strategic planning, financial management, and continuous adaptation** to surmount these obstacles. Finally, a **collaborative path forward** is advocated by respondents. Consistent communication, protocol adherence, and alignment with government initiatives are seen as crucial for navigating the industry's transformation. This **collective effort** is key to a thriving future for Boracay's tourism sector.

In pursuit of recovery, hotels are turning their attention inwards, prioritizing the domestic market and employing a range of targeted strategies. Coupons, flexible product packages, and search engine optimization (SEO) are key tools in their arsenal, as highlighted by the current study and echoed by Heredia-Colaço and Rodrigues' (2021) recent research. This emphasis on marketing and sales is further evidenced by their findings, where hotels reported significant investments in attracting new customers through innovative packages and special offers. Additionally, multiple studies – including Hao et al. (2020), Heredia-Colaço and Rodrigues (2021), and Lai and Wong (2020) – underscore the value of specific strategic marketing measures in weathering the current crisis. These include targeting local travelers with dedicated campaigns and offers, developing new products and services to generate alternative revenue streams, and enhancing loyalty programs to incentivize repeat business. By embracing these data-driven approaches, hotels can effectively navigate the challenging landscape and attract new customers in the domestic market.

In conclusion, Boracay's hotel industry demonstrates resilience and adaptability, but challenges persist. The combined forces of government support, industry ingenuity, and collaborative action will be instrumental in securing a sustained recovery. This study offers valuable insights for stakeholders as they navigate the uncertainties of the new normal, paving the way for a brighter future for Boracay.

The Experiences Encountered by the Hotel following its Transition to a Better Normal in Boracay Island

	Codes	Representative Excerpts from Qualitative Interviews
1. Government Support and Collaboration (34)	Positive Perception of Government Support Suggestions for More Government Programs Misalignment between Government Sectors Inconsistent Government Policies Need for Collaboration with Government	• Hotel A: "It is really pleasing that our government is supporting our industry. It is not only giving our country a chance to rise again but to help Filipino workers under the tourism industry to regain their finances." • Hotel F: "Honestly, I really appreciate our government focusing on the beautification of our tourist destinations, but I noticed that the local government and our sectors in tourism are not connected with each other sometimes, and it caused misleading to us, in private sectors. I must suggest that our government sectors should be more open and more aligned to each other." • Hotel H: "The Department of Tourism really exceeded their efforts to maintain the market, but it wasn't enough. No specific support and no definite plans from the end of the government like lockdowns are inconsistent. The government needs to consider long-term implications of the crisis, gaps in government and industry preparedness and response capacity."

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2. Operational Adaptations and Challenges (38)	Company Adaptations to the New Normal Operational Challenges Due to Changing Guidelines Strategies for Transformation Challenges in Visitor and Supplier Management Internal and External Obstacles	• Hotel J: "Late and so slow to make a decision-making process but they're doing their best to help us since tourism is the number one supply of the Philippine economy." • Hotel A: "To adopt the new normal and make it as our better NORMAL way of giving service to our guest." • Hotel C: "We made sure that no employee will be left behind, shortened work hours to balance also the employer-employee opportunities." • Hotel D: "Guests became few during the pandemic and we have to adopt the rotation duties of the staff." • Hotel G: "Been adapting to the new normal. Cashless transactions and digitalization of processes." • Hotel K: "Update the hotel profile time to time about the new policies or safety protocols and digital marketing utilization." • Hotel O: "Upgrading and upskilling our internal customers. New standard operating procedure for better normal and orienting our internal customers and upskilling them." • Hotel Q: "Environmental scanning and crisis management or contingency plans."
	Financial Management	• Hotel F: "We have modified our booking system. We handle it by knowing the process and no shortcut. Now, it is successfully used." • Hotel J: "Intense technology utilization and information dissemination. Ensuring customer and employee safety. Digital payments for past transactions. Serve as quarantine facility." • Hotel Q: "Flexible SOP and its implementation and Accurate Communication Information Dissemination to customers to gain its trust and travel confidence."
3. Communication and Information Dissemination (16)	Importance of Clear Communication Information Dissemination Challengess	
	Customer Confidence and Communication	
4. Employee Management and Training (10)	Workforce Shortages and Retention Employee Training and Upskilling	• HOTEL F: "Under manpower due to retention. Solution: Know the abilities of each employee and expand their functions."
5. Financial Management and Resource Utilization (10)	Financial Struggles and Management Loan Terms and Conditions	• HOTEL D: "Just follow what is required by the approving agencies in order to continue the hotel's operation. We just need to conform to all the protocols in order to continue our operations. It may cause us additional expenses but what is important is the safety of the guests and staff to be able to render services amidst pandemic recovery."
6. Safety Protocols and Hygiene Measures (8)	Focus on Safety and Hygiene Adherence to Health Protocols	• HOTEL G: "The guidelines are based on IATF. Priority is health & safety."
7. Marketing and Sales Strategies (8)	Marketing Plans and Sales Strategies	

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8. Operational Procedures and Policies (10)	Customer Behavior and Market Analysis Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) Implementation Policy Flexibility and Adaptation	- HOTEL F: "Expand marketing plans leading to more products and more future sales." - HOTEL K: "Not satisfied due to inconsistent update the hotel profile time to time about the new policies or safety protocols and digital marketing utilization."
9. Planning and Strategic Management (9)	Strategic Planning and Management Crisis Management and Contingency Planning	HOTEL I: "Shift to policy and business strategic management between the environmental and social and economic status previously."
10. Technology Utilization and Digitalization (4)	Technology Adoption and Digitalization	HOTEL G: "Been adapting to new normal. Cashless transactions and digitalization of processes."

5. The Recovery Plans, Strategies, and Practices of Hotels in the Time of its Transition to a Better Normal in Boracay Island

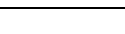
The pandemic dealt a heavy blow to the hospitality industry, leaving many hotels reeling. However, the data paints a surprisingly optimistic picture, revealing a story not just of recovery, but of **transformation**. Hotels are not passively bouncing back; they are actively metamorphosing into more resilient, adaptable, and **guest-centric** entities, poised to thrive in the "better normal" phase. One key theme driving this transformation is **Resilient Operational Restructuring**. Faced with challenges like reduced travel demand and labor shortages, hotels are becoming leaner and more agile. Measures like **cross-training staff and focusing on cash flow management** demonstrate their dexterity in navigating a dynamic environment. But resilience alone isn't enough. In a world still grappling with health concerns, **Safety-Centric Transformation is paramount**.

Hotels are prioritizing guest well-being with **strict adherence to health protocols, regular testing, and mask distribution**. This unwavering commitment to safety builds trust and **encourages travel in a cautious post-pandemic world**. However, the transformation doesn't stop there. Hotels are also embracing the **Tech Takeover**, harnessing the power of technology to streamline operations, personalize experiences, and reach new audiences. This **tech-driven approach**, encompassing everything from targeted online marketing to automated cleaning procedures, **enhances efficiency and creates a competitive edge**. Yet, technology alone cannot ensure a complete recovery. Collaboration across the industry and with government agencies is vital. This brings us to the theme of **Collaborative Recovery**. Hotels are actively engaging in **efforts like vaccination drives, adhering to regulations, and forming industry partnerships**. This united front is building a **stronger, more resilient tourism and hospitality sector**.

Finally, recovery isn't just about bouncing back; it's about adapting to evolving market demands. This brings us to the final theme: **Strategic Business Adaptation**. Hotels are tailoring their offerings to changing market preferences, embracing **flexible booking systems, innovative pricing strategies, or curated experiences**. By being **proactive and data-driven**, they ensure long-term sustainability in a changing market.

Despite the challenges of canceled and rebooked reservations, hotels in Boracay Island are actively working to rebuild guest trust and safety, aligning with the Department of Tourism's updated recovery plan. This echoes findings by Hao et al. (2020) and Rodriguez-Anton & Alonso-Almeida (2020) who emphasize the importance of restoring customer confidence during crises. To achieve this, some hotel chains have implemented strategies like offering free cancellation, assisting with rebooking, expanding loyalty programs, and enhancing membership benefits, reassuring guests of their commitment to safety and flexibility. While Lai and Wong (2020) might have indicated different outcomes, the focus on trust and safety remains crucial for the Boracay Island's hotel industry to navigate the current challenges and attract guests.

In conclusion, the data paints a clear picture: hotels aren't merely recovering, they're actively transforming. By embracing these five key themes, they are demonstrating remarkable resilience, adaptability, and a commitment to exceeding guest expectations in the "better normal" phase and beyond.

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The Recovery Plans, Strategies, and Practices of Hotels in the Time of its Transition to a Better Normal in Boracay Island			Codes	Representative Excerpts from Qualitative Interviews
1. Operational Changes and Strategies (34)			Resilient Operational Restructuring Safety-Centric Transformation Digital Innovation Collaborative Recovery	• HOTEL A: "To focus on the strength of our business and omit our non-revenue business." • HOTEL B: "Better control procedure requirements." • HOTEL C: "We strengthen the use of digital marketing in the promotion of our products and services and we continue to follow protocols." • HOTEL D: "Activated online reservations." • HOTEL E: "Wearing face masks at all times and maintaining cleanliness and sanitation practices due to viruses spreading as the new normal phase." • HOTEL F: "Change in payment method." • HOTEL H: "Sales and marketing strategies turn into more digitally focused and flexible products and services and safe workforce and revised human resource or workforce benefits." • HOTEL I: "Address workers' needs, strong coordinated policy of action aligning to the TRRP of the DOT in order to mitigate the effect and support of the recovery." • HOTEL J: "Previously we don't give focus on health matters of employees and guests, now that's our top priority." • HOTEL K: "Revision of company business and strategic plans focusing on financial, human resource, and marketing."
			Strategic Business Adaptation	
2. Compliance and Regulations (17)			Government Regulations and Compliance	• HOTEL D: "To conform with the DOT's requirements for us to be able to operate." • HOTEL E: "To still implement the COVID-19 health protocol." • HOTEL G: "Mostly health and safety protocols." • HOTEL L: "Safety and healthy protocols still on top of our priority."
			Adherence to Safety Protocols	
3. Employee Management and Training (18)			Workforce Restructuring and Benefits Employee Health and Safety	• HOTEL C: "Every week antigen test to make sure that every employee is healthy before providing any service to our guests." • HOTEL F: "They offer constant seminars online. This is very effective to us because it delivers the new information planned by the government and sometimes a waking up call to us too to do best." • HOTEL H: "Corporate social responsibility like front beach cleanup drive, mental health training and seminars for our employees, open door policy - internal customers feedback to operation."
			Training and Seminars	
4. Business Planning and Management (21)			Business Plan Revision	• HOTEL D: "Activated online reservations." • HOTEL F: "Change in payment method." • HOTEL K: "Revision of company business and strategic plans focusing on financial, human resource, and marketing."
			Financial Management and Planning	

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5. Government Engagement and Programs (14)	Marketing Strategies	business and strategic plans focusing on financial, human resource, and marketing." • HOTEL A: "Libreng sakay program and the project for returning OFW. It is really helpful to our company and it is one of the reasons that we stay afloat amidst the pandemic." • HOTEL H: "Updated Tourism Response and Recovery Plan, I agree and many non-profit organizations and associations within our area are focusing and helping each other supporting the said plan in order to recover a more stronger and resilient tourism industry." • HOTEL L: "Meeting up with industry operators like the sharing economy association in our destination as we meet and plan and help one another for collaboration." • HOTEL O: "Adopting better normal new policies and emphasizing digital transformation in all our operations and prioritizing safety and health for customers and employees."
	Government Collaboration and Programs	
	DOT Recovery Plan (TRRP)	
6. Communication and Information Dissemination (8)	Clear Communication of Safety Protocols	
	Information Dissemination	
7. Technology Utilization and Innovation (7)	Digital Marketing Emphasis	
	Technology Adoption	

6. Proposed Business Continuity Model for Hotel Business in Boracay Island a Strategic Considerations in Better Normal



Boracay's tourism industry, while recovering, faces a dynamic "better normal" landscape. To navigate these uncertainties and ensure success, hotels can adopt a robust business continuity model built on several key pillars:

- ✓ **Diversification and Adaptability:** Expanding beyond traditional accommodation is crucial. Offering quarantine packages, co-working spaces, themed events, and targeted promotions caters to diverse traveler segments, mitigating risk and creating multiple income streams. Embracing agility through technology is equally important. Cross-trained staff, online booking systems, and contactless solutions ensure smooth operations amidst changing regulations, while enhancing guest experience and efficiency.
- ✓ **Safety-Centric Transformation:** Prioritizing guest safety is paramount. Rigorous adherence to health protocols, regular testing, and mask distribution build trust and address ongoing health concerns.
- ✓ **Tech-Driven Efficiency:** Technology empowers hotels to personalize guest experiences, reach new audiences, and streamline operations. Targeted online marketing, automated cleaning procedures, and online reservation systems contribute to a competitive edge.
- ✓ **Collaborative Recovery:** Collective action is key. Active engagement in vaccination drives, adherence to regulations, and industry partnerships with local authorities and other tourism players contribute to a stronger, more resilient sector.

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- ✓ **Strategic Business Adaptation:** Continuous adaptation and data-driven planning are essential. Tailoring offerings to evolving market preferences through flexible booking systems, innovative pricing strategies, and curated experiences ensures long-term sustainability.
- ✓ **Customer-Centric Focus:** Prioritizing guest satisfaction fosters trust and loyalty. Open communication, personalized interactions, prompt concern resolution, loyalty programs, and digital tools for recommendations and communication achieve this.
- ✓ **Additional Considerations:** Financial preparedness through healthy cash reserves and financing options, workforce engagement through training and competitive benefits, and robust crisis management plans are crucial for unforeseen events.

By implementing these strategic considerations, Boracay's hotels can transform into resilient, guest-centric entities, thriving in the better normal and shaping a brighter future for the island's tourism sector. The proposed business continuity model aims to ensure the resilience and adaptability of hotel businesses in Boracay Island in the better normal. By focusing on collaborative recovery initiatives, crisis survival strategies, strategic business adaptation, tech-driven efficiency, diversification, and safety-centric transformation, hotels can navigate challenges and thrive in the evolving landscape. Regular assessment and adjustment of these strategies will be crucial to staying ahead of market trends and meeting customer expectations.

(13) Conclusions and Recommendations

Conclusions

1. **Critical Success Factors for Boracay Hotels in Better Normal:** Boracay hotels are thriving through diversification, adaptability, innovation, customer focus, strategic planning, and resilient crisis strategies, paving the way for a successful future in the evolving hospitality landscape.
2. **Experiences of Boracay Hotels in Better Normal:** Although facing challenges like frequent guideline changes and external hurdles, Boracay's hotel industry demonstrates resilience and adaptability. Collaboration and government support are crucial for overcoming obstacles and securing a sustained recovery.
3. **Recovery Plans and Strategies of Boracay Hotels:** Boracay hotels are actively transforming into resilient, adaptable, and guest-centric entities through resilient operational restructuring, safety-centric transformation, tech takeover, collaborative recovery, and strategic business adaptation, ensuring long-term success in the better normal.

Recommendations

1. **Capitalize on Success Factors:** Double down on diversification and innovation. Explore unique offerings beyond traditional accommodation, like themed packages, local partnerships, and sustainable experiences. Continuously experiment and adapt to attract diverse traveler segments and stay ahead of trends.
2. **Overcome Challenges through Collaboration:** Form strong partnerships with government agencies and industry stakeholders. Advocate for consistent regulations, infrastructure investment, and collaborative problem-solving to address frequent guideline changes and external hurdles.
3. **Enhance Transformation for Long-Term Success:** Embrace technology in all aspects of operations. Implement automated solutions for efficiency, personalize guest experiences with digital tools, and invest in targeted online marketing to reach new audiences. Foster a collaborative recovery through joint marketing initiatives and industry-wide safety protocols.

(14) Output (Indicate the specific products, processes or services which the project has produced; quantify when possible.)

Proposed Business Continuity Model for Hotel Business in Boracay Island a Strategic Considerations in Better Normal

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Boracay's tourism industry, while recovering, faces a dynamic "better normal" landscape. To navigate these uncertainties and ensure success, hotels can adopt a robust business continuity model built on several key pillars:

- ✓ **Diversification and Adaptability:** Expanding beyond traditional accommodation is crucial. Offering quarantine packages, co-working spaces, themed events, and targeted promotions caters to diverse traveler segments, mitigating risk and creating multiple income streams. Embracing agility through technology is equally important. Cross-trained staff, online booking systems, and contactless solutions ensure smooth operations amidst changing regulations, while enhancing guest experience and efficiency.
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- ✓ **Collaborative Recovery:** Collective action is key. Active engagement in vaccination drives, adherence to regulations, and industry partnerships with local authorities and other tourism players contribute to a stronger, more resilient sector.
- ✓ **Strategic Business Adaptation:** Continuous adaptation and data-driven planning are essential. Tailoring offerings to evolving market preferences through flexible booking systems, innovative pricing strategies, and curated experiences ensures long-term sustainability.
- ✓ **Customer-Centric Focus:** Prioritizing guest satisfaction fosters trust and loyalty. Open communication, personalized interactions, prompt concern resolution, loyalty programs, and digital tools for recommendations and communication achieve this.
- ✓ **Additional Considerations:** Financial preparedness through healthy cash reserves and financing options, workforce engagement through training and competitive benefits, and robust crisis management plans are crucial for unforeseen events.

By implementing these strategic considerations, Boracay's hotels can transform into resilient, guest-centric entities, thriving in the better normal and shaping a brighter future for the island's tourism sector.

Detailed Output/ Deliverables:

Proposed Business Continuity Model for Hotel Business in Boracay Island: Strategic Considerations in the Better Normal

1. Collaborative Recovery Initiatives

- **Partnership with Local Businesses**
 - **Deliverables:**
 - Identify potential local business partners.
 - Establish collaboration agreements.
 - Launch joint promotional campaigns.

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○ Actions: ▪ Conduct market research to identify suitable partners. ▪ Organize meetings and negotiate terms. ▪ Develop joint marketing strategies and materials. ● Joint Marketing Campaigns ○ Deliverables: ▪ Design and execute marketing campaigns. ▪ Track and analyze campaign performance. ○ Actions: ▪ Collaborate with marketing teams to create campaign content. ▪ Utilize social media, local media, and online platforms for promotion. ▪ Monitor key performance indicators (KPIs) and adjust strategies accordingly.
2. Crisis Survival Strategies ● Crisis Management ○ Deliverables: ▪ Develop a comprehensive crisis management plan. ▪ Conduct regular crisis response drills. ○ Actions: ▪ Identify potential crisis scenarios and response strategies. ▪ Train staff on crisis response procedures. ▪ Review and update the crisis management plan regularly. ● Financial Preparedness ○ Deliverables: ▪ Create a financial contingency plan. ▪ Establish an emergency fund. ○ Actions: ▪ Assess current financial status and identify vulnerabilities. ▪ Set aside a percentage of revenue for the emergency fund. ▪ Regularly review and adjust the financial contingency plan. ● Workforce Engagement ○ Deliverables: ▪ Implement employee engagement programs. ▪ Provide mental health support and resources. ○ Actions: ▪ Conduct surveys to assess employee satisfaction and needs. ▪ Organize team-building activities and workshops. ▪ Offer counseling services and stress management programs.
3. Strategic Business Adaptation ● Flexibility in Offerings ○ Deliverables: ▪ Develop flexible service packages. ▪ Create customizable experiences for guests. ○ Actions: ▪ Analyze customer preferences and trends. ▪ Design packages that cater to diverse needs and preferences. ▪ Train staff to offer personalized services. ● Market Trend Analysis ○ Deliverables: ▪ Conduct regular market analysis reports. ▪ Identify emerging trends and opportunities. ○ Actions: ▪ Use data analytics tools to monitor market trends. ▪ Stay updated on industry developments and competitor activities. ▪ Adjust business strategies based on analysis findings.
4. Tech-Driven Efficiency ● Automation of Operations ○ Deliverables: ▪ Implement automated systems for routine tasks. ▪ Train staff to use new technologies.

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○ Actions: ▪ Identify areas where automation can increase efficiency. ▪ Install and configure automation tools. ▪ Provide training sessions for staff on new systems. ● Data Analytics for Decision Making ○ Deliverables: ▪ Develop a data analytics framework. ▪ Use data insights to inform strategic decisions. ○ Actions: ▪ Collect and analyze operational and customer data. ▪ Create dashboards and reports for decision-makers. ▪ Regularly review data to identify areas for improvement. 5. Diversification and Adaptability ● Expanding Services ○ Deliverables: ▪ Introduce new services and amenities. ▪ Develop partnerships for outsourced services. ○ Actions: ▪ Conduct market research to identify service gaps. ▪ Design and launch new service offerings. ▪ Collaborate with third-party providers for additional services. ● Offering New Experiences ○ Deliverables: ▪ Create unique guest experiences. ▪ Develop themed events and activities. ○ Actions: ▪ Brainstorm and design new guest experiences. ▪ Partner with local cultural and recreational organizations. ▪ Promote new experiences through various channels. 6. Safety-Centric Transformation ● Enhanced Sanitation Measures ○ Deliverables: ▪ Develop and implement enhanced cleaning protocols. ▪ Obtain relevant health and safety certifications. ○ Actions: ▪ Train housekeeping staff on new sanitation procedures. ▪ Use high-quality cleaning products and equipment. ▪ Regularly audit cleaning practices for compliance. ● Contactless Technology Integration ○ Deliverables: ▪ Implement contactless check-in/check-out systems. ▪ Introduce contactless payment options. ○ Actions: ▪ Research and select suitable contactless technology solutions. ▪ Install and configure systems for seamless operation. ▪ Educate guests and staff on using contactless options.
(15) Technology Transfer Activity Conducted
(16) Economic Analysis
(17) Acknowledgments With deepest gratitude, I thank God for His guidance and my family for their unwavering support. To my friends and the university, thank you for enriching this journey. My appreciation extends to the tourism & hospitality industry and the Department of Tourism Region VI for their invaluable contributions.

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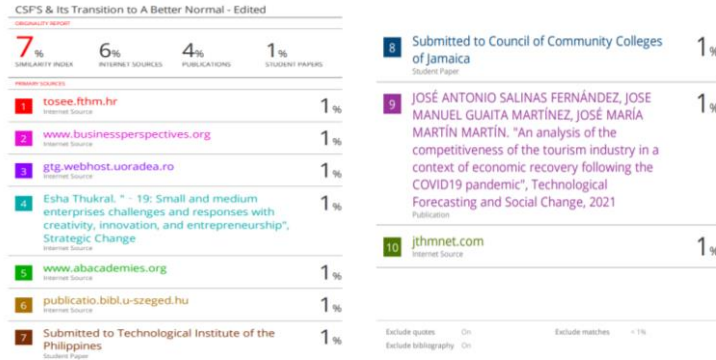
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J|A

JHONNEL J. ABALAJON

PROFESSOR

 Sigma, Roxas, 5816, Germany

 +639634633963

 jhonnlabalajon@gmail.com



EDUCATION

DOCTOR IN HOSPITALITY MANAGEMENT
Philippine Women's University / Taft Ave., Manila
Completed Academic Requirements Doctor in Hospitality Management, Candidate

MASTER OF SCIENCE IN HOTEL AND RESTAURANT MANAGEMENT (MSHRM)
Philippine Women's University / Taft Ave., Manila / 2018

BACHELOR OF SCIENCE IN HOTEL AND RESTAURANT MANAGEMENT
Capiz State University / Sigma, Capiz, Philippines / 2012

- Capiz State University, 2008-2012
- Outstanding School Paper Staff of the Year 2010-2012
- Outstanding Supreme Student Council Senator 2011
- On-The-Job Trainee of the Year
- Best Debating Team of the Year
- University Awardee
- Gov. Victor A. Tanco Sr. Excellence Awardee
- Cong. Mark Aeron Sambar Awardee
- Congresswoman Jane Tan Castro, Excellence Awardee
- Ave Excellence Awardee
- Civil Service Awardee

HIGH SCHOOL DIPLOMA
Vicente Andaya Sr. National High School / Poblacion Sur, Sigma, Capiz, Philippines / 2008

WORK EXPERIENCE

Capiz State University
Oct 2020 - Present
Roxas City, Philippines

INSTRUCTOR I
Instructor I, Tourism and Hospitality Management Department
Gender & Development Focal Person
Research Adviser and Panelist
Capiz State University Sigma Satellite College
October 2020 - Present

Researcher
Completed 3 Research entitled:
1. "Impact of Community Extension Programs To Capiz State University Faculty & Students"
2. "Perception of the Students Towards the Bachelor of Science in Hospitality Management Department Home-Based Internship Program of Capiz State University"
3. Perception of the Students towards the Bachelor of Science in Hospitality Management Department Home-based Internship Program of Capiz State University

Subjects taught:
1. Introduction to Meetings, Incentives, Conference and Exhibitions
2. Accommodation Operation and Management
3. Ergonomics in Tourism and Hospitality Management
4. Hospitality & Tourism Facilities Management & Design

Colegio de San Juan de Letran
Sep 2016 - May 2020
Calamba, Calamba City, Laguna, Philippines

INSTRUCTOR
Major Key Role & Contributions:

- Library Committee 2019-2020
- Tourism & HRM/HM Research Adviser & Panelist
- Building Course Curriculum
- Preparing Course Syllabi
- Mentoring and Coaching Students
- Create and Prepare Supplementary Materials
- Community Extension Service Moderator 2019-2020
- Research Adviser and Panelist

Subjects taught:

- Applied Business Tools and Technologies for Tourism and Hospitality
- Tourism & Hospitality Management Information System